DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Is There Really Reward for Misvot?

Derech Hashem 1:2:3-5

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 1, Chapter 2, paragraph 3 to the end of the chapter **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 14 January 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

The Rabbi recapped. Because Hashem is perfect and good, He wants to give perfect goodness, which is found only in Him, so He gives it by letting human beings connect to Him. Why not simply hand it to us? Because we must take ownership and authorship of that goodness. For Hashem, goodness is not incidental but intrinsic to His essence, so for us too it must be achieved, not given on a plate. That is why the world contains concepts of perfection and concepts of deficiency, with man in between to choose. When you choose the good you incorporate perfection within yourself, and become fit to bask in Hashem's presence in the World to Come.

He also recalled the discussion of Gehinnom: the real "hell" is karet, being cut off, which is not so much a punishment as a reality. Gehinnom itself, at most twelve months, is a purification that washes off the small bruises. "No good God would want to punish someone."

There is no "reward and punishment"

Before reading paragraph 3, the Rabbi explained its idea "outside," a point the Rambam also makes. "There is no concept of reward and punishment in Torah. I repeat."

The word reward implies that you do X and get Y. A lawyer works a month and receives notes and coins, but there is no intrinsic connection between the work and the money; it is an arbitrary way of rewarding him. Unfortunately most people think of Torah this way, treating Hashem like a vending machine: "If I say this segulah on this day at this time, I'm pressing this button of God, and therefore I'm going to get this money."

The reality is simple. You choose good, you become a better person, and because you are a better person you are automatically more connected to Hashem. "Doing X is in itself the reward." The reward of a misvah is the misvah itself.

The treadmill. If you run on a treadmill every day (as we learned in the Rambam, one should exercise every morning), would we say your "reward" is losing weight? It sounds wrong. The result is that you lose weight. Nobody rewards you by taking weight away; it simply happens.

"You run on the treadmill of the Torah, you keep the misvah, you become a better person." The result is that you are more spiritual and closer to Hashem.

He added that when misvot are described as diamonds and gold and pearls, as Shelomo HaMelekh does in Mishlei, that is all a mashal, a way to motivate, like telling someone on the treadmill he will feel strong, happy and rich. People prefer tangible promises, and they like being told that a particular night of Hanukkah or Purim brings a particular blessing. "You never hear of the times it never happens. You only hear of the times it does happen."

"This will change a whole person's perception... Don't think of Torah in these terms."

Paragraph 3: perfection is cleaving

The Ramhal says that apart from becoming similar to Hashem by acquiring perfection, by that very act a person cleaves to Him. The Rabbi called this the key sentence: striving for perfection and cleaving to Hashem are one thing, "running on the treadmill and losing weight."

Hashem is the true perfection, so all perfection is associated with Him. Any perfection in this world, even if not the ultimate perfection, is a branch of Him. And all deficiency, all bad in the world, is only a concealment of Hashem's face, a point the Ramhal will return to when he explains why there is bad in the world. The illumination of His countenance is the root of all perfection; its concealment is the root of all deficiency. The more concealment, the more deficiency.

Man stands between the two. When he strengthens himself and acquires perfection, he automatically cleaves to Hashem, because all good stems from Him.

The beam of light. Picture Hashem's presence as a beam of light shining down, like the beam at the start of every Mr Bean episode. Do good, and you draw yourself into the light. Do bad, and you step out of it. The more you perfect yourself, the further into the light you come, and because you brought yourself there, the goodness is truly yours, and you can bask fully in it. "What's the biggest reward? With Hashem. You do good, you're with Hashem. Full stop."

A whole universe for one purpose

For this system to exist, with a human being able to choose between good and bad, perfection and deficiency, a whole universe is needed, with countless details and relationships between them.

The creature destined for this great closeness to Hashem is man, and he is the principle of all creation. Everything else contributes to that goal and is secondary. "Animals are very nice. We have to look after animals. But they are not important relative to human beings." Humanity as a whole is the core of creation. The animals below us and the angels above us all exist for this purpose, and the Ramhal will later explain the role of the angels.

He recalled the gorilla in a zoo that was shot when a child came near its enclosure, and the uproar that followed. He called the objection misguided: since man is the core of the universe, even a slight risk to a human life outweighs the rest of creation.

What is perfection?

Until now "perfection" has been abstract. The final paragraph of the chapter defines it: perfection is intellect and good character traits. Deficiency is materiality, physical and base things, and bad character traits. Man is placed between them to choose.

The deficiency means letting your character be selfish, earthly and material, always seeking the physical. Perfection is intellectual refinement and refinement of character.

A participant asked whether striving to perfect the intellect differs for each person. The Rabbi agreed: it is all relative, and you go as far as you can. That is how the Ramhal holds. The Rambam, he said, disagreed: for the Rambam, if you lack the intellect to reach knowledge of Hashem, you cannot get there. According to the Ramhal, even a person of limited ability who uses his intellect as much as he can has achieved perfection at his level.

That completed Chapter 2. "Go over it… these are fundamentals, we must know them."

Summary

- Torah has no "reward and punishment" in the sense of payment; the result of a misvah is the person you become and your closeness to Hashem.
- Acquiring perfection and cleaving to Hashem are one and the same, like running on a treadmill and losing weight.
- All good branches from Hashem's revealed face, and all bad comes from its concealment; doing good brings you into the light.
- Man is the purpose of creation, and everything else serves that purpose.
- Perfection is intellect and good character; deficiency is materiality and bad character, each measured relative to the person.

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